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Formatting Guide

Bold text = emphasis.
Green dotted-underline text = glossary tooltip. Popup definition on first appearance per article.
→ *Green italic text* = internal link to another article.
DIAGRAM and INTERACTIVE = visual placeholders with caption + designer note.

Article Summary

Articles 1-15: Foundation, Beginner Strategy, and Intermediate (REVISED)

1. How to Play Backgammon — 1,573 words
2. Backgammon Board Setup Explained — 994 words
3. The Backgammon Doubling Cube — 2,088 words
4. How Backgammon Scoring Works — 1,239 words
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BEGINNER · 10 min read

How to Play Backgammon

The complete beginner's guide: board, pieces, movement, hitting, bearing off, and scoring.

Backgammon Basics: The Goal of the Game

Backgammon is a race between two players. You each have 15 checkers, and the goal is to move all of them around the board and off before your opponent does the same. Dice tell you how far to move, but you choose which checkers to move and when.

That choice is where all the fun is. The dice hand you a little puzzle each turn, and your job is to solve it. In any single game, luck can absolutely swing the result, and we've all been on the wrong end of double 6s at the worst possible moment. But over a session or a match, the player who makes better choices wins more often. That's what keeps people hooked.

The equipment is simple: a board with 24 points, 15 checkers per player, two pairs of dice, dice cups, and a **doubling cube**. The cube isn't a die. It tracks the stakes of the game and is central to competitive play.

How to Set Up the Backgammon Board

The board has 24 narrow triangles called **points**. A raised strip down the middle, known as the **bar**, divides the board in half. This gives you four sections of six points each:

- **Your home board** (points 1–6)
- **Your outer board** (points 7–12)
- **Your opponent's outer board** (points 13–18)
- **Your opponent's home board** (points 19–24)

Each player starts with 15 checkers arranged in a fixed pattern: two on the 24-point, five on the 13-point, three on the 8-point, and five on the 6-point. This arrangement is mirrored for the other player.

→ For a full walkthrough of checker placement and board orientation, see Board Setup Explained.

🖼️ **DIAGRAM**

Caption: *The backgammon starting position with all 30 checkers placed.*
Designer note: Full board in starting position. Number each point 1–24 from the perspective of one player, colour-coded by quadrant (home board, outer board, opponent outer, opponent home). Label the bar. Show both players' checkers in their starting positions.

Rules of Play: Movement and Mechanics

Each player rolls two dice. The numbers are played separately: a roll of 5-3 means you move one checker 5 points forward and another (or the same one) 3 points forward. Every move must land on an open point: one that isn't occupied by two or more of the opponent's checkers.

Rolling doubles is a treat: you get four moves instead of two. Roll double 4s and you have four separate moves of 4 points each.

If no legal move exists, you forfeit that portion of the roll. If only one die can be played, you must play the higher number when possible.

The first roll of the game works differently: each player rolls one die, and the player who rolls higher goes first using both numbers. If both players roll the same number, they roll again.

🕹️ **INTERACTIVE**
Caption: *Try it: move checkers using the dice roll shown.*
Designer note: Starting position with a pre-set roll displayed (e.g., 6-3). User taps/drags checkers to make legal moves. Highlight valid landing points. After the move, show whether the user's play matched the recommended move and why.

Hitting and Entering from the Bar

A point with only one checker on it (a **blot**) is vulnerable. If you land on an opponent's blot, that checker goes to the bar. They can't make any other move until they bring that checker back into the game by rolling a number that matches an open point in your home board.

If the opponent can't re-enter (because you have made all the necessary points in your home board), they lose their entire turn. This is called **fanning** or **dancing**. It's as frustrating as it sounds, and just as satisfying when you're the one doing it.

Bearing Off: How to Finish the Game

Once all 15 of your checkers are in your home board (points 1–6), you start **bearing off**. Roll a number that matches a point with your checker on it, and that checker comes off the board.

If you roll a number higher than your highest occupied point, you bear off from the highest point instead. If you can't bear off or move, you must move a checker within the home board if a legal move exists.

→ For rules, edge cases, and safe technique, see Bearing Off.

Scoring and Winning Conditions

A standard win scores 1 point. If the losing player hasn't borne off any checkers, the winner scores a **gammon** (2 points). If the loser also has a checker in the winner's home board or on the bar, the winner scores a **backgammon** (3 points). All of these values are multiplied by the current doubling cube value.

The Doubling Cube Explained

The **doubling cube** is a marker (not a die) with faces showing 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, and 64. It starts in the centre of the board with the 64 face up, representing a value of 1. At the start of your turn (before rolling), you can offer to double the stakes. Your opponent either accepts (takes) and plays for the new stake, or declines (drops) and loses the current game at the old stake.

Once someone takes a double, only they can offer the next one. This back-and-forth adds a whole extra layer of strategy: when do you push your advantage, and when do you accept the risk of playing on at higher stakes? You'll develop a feel for it over time. Don't worry about getting it perfect right away.

→ For cube strategy, market losers, and match play rules, see The Doubling Cube.

Basic Backgammon Strategy for Beginners

Even with a basic grasp of the rules, a few principles will improve your results right away. And here's the encouraging part: just knowing these puts you ahead of most casual players.

Opening moves matter. The first roll sets the tone of the game. Certain rolls have well-established best plays that have been tested over decades of analysis. Learning even a handful of these gives you an edge over opponents who move on instinct alone.

Blocking beats running (early on). Building consecutive points in front of your opponent's checkers restricts their movement. A wall of made points (a **prime**) is one of the strongest structures in the game. Focus on making points rather than racing individual checkers home.

Balance safety and aggression. Leaving blots is sometimes necessary and sometimes correct. Picture this: a blot on your 5-point that helps you build a key point next turn? That's a smart risk. A lone checker stranded deep in the opponent's home board with no backup? That one's going to cost you. Every position calls for a different balance, and reading that balance is what makes you a better player.

Variations and Digital Play

The standard rules described here are used in most backgammon worldwide, but two popular variants change the game:

Nackgammon, created by Nack Ballard, moves one checker each from the 13-point and the 6-point to the 24-point. Each player starts with four back checkers instead of two. This creates more contact and longer games.

Acey-Deucey is a military variant where all checkers start off the board and enter during play. The board begins empty, and the game plays very differently from standard backgammon.

Online play brings backgammon to a global audience. Platforms like backgammon.com let you play rated games, review your moves with analysis tools, and track your performance over time. Digital play also handles setup, rules enforcement, and scoring automatically, making it an ideal way to learn.

FAQ

What happens if you roll doubles in backgammon?
You get four moves of that number instead of two. For example, rolling double 3s gives you four separate moves of 3 points each. You can split these among different checkers or use them all on one checker, as long as each individual move lands on an open point.

What is the difference between a gammon and a backgammon?
A gammon (worth 2 points) happens when the winner bears off all their checkers while the loser hasn't borne off any. A backgammon (worth 3 points) is even more extreme: the loser hasn't borne off any checkers and still has at least one checker on the bar or in the winner's home board.

Can you pass your turn in backgammon?

No. If you have a legal move, you must play it. You only skip part or all of your turn when no legal move exists. If you can play one die but not both, you must play the higher number when possible.

How do you determine who goes first?
Each player rolls one die. The player who rolls the higher number goes first and uses both dice (their own and their opponent's) as the opening roll. If both players roll the same number, they roll again until someone rolls higher.

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. How many checkers does each player start with?
○ 12
◉ 15 ← Correct
○ 20

2. If you can only play one of your two dice, which must you play?
○ The lower number
◉ The higher number ← Correct
○ Either one, your choice

3. When can you start bearing off?
○ After crossing the midpoint
◉ When all 15 checkers are in your home board ← Correct
○ After rolling doubles

BEGINNER · 5 min read

Backgammon Board Setup Explained

Everything you need to place the checkers, position the cube, and start a game correctly.

Setting up a backgammon board takes less than a minute once you know the pattern. Every game begins with the same arrangement, and getting it right matters: even one checker on the wrong point throws off the opening. The good news is that the pattern's easy to remember, and after a few games it will feel automatic. This guide walks through the board, the checkers, the equipment, and the variations you might encounter.

Understanding the Backgammon Board Layout

The board has 24 narrow triangles called **points**, numbered 1 to 24. A raised divider down the middle, known as the **bar**, splits the board into two halves:

- **Your home board:** points 1–6 (the quadrant closest to you, where you bear off).
- **Your outer board:** points 7–12.
- **Opponent's outer board:** points 13–18.
- **Opponent's home board:** points 19–24.

The numbering works in opposite directions for each player. Your 1-point is your opponent's 24-point, and vice versa. Colours on the triangles alternate for visibility but have no gameplay function.

→ For a full explanation of all board terms, see Backgammon Glossary.

🖼️ **DIAGRAM**
Caption: *The four quadrants of the backgammon board.*
Designer note: Full empty board with all 24 points visible. Label each quadrant (home board, outer board, opponent's outer board, opponent's home board). Number the points 1–24 from one player's perspective. Highlight the bar in the centre. Use colour coding to distinguish the four quadrants.

Step-by-Step Checker Placement (The Starting Array)

Each player sets up 15 checkers in the same fixed pattern. Think of it as the **2-5-3-5 rule**:

- **2 checkers** on the 24-point (your farthest point, deep in the opponent's home board).

- **5 checkers** on the 13-point (the **midpoint**, at the start of your opponent's outer board).
- **3 checkers** on the 8-point (in your outer board).
- **5 checkers** on the 6-point (in your home board).

Your opponent places their 15 checkers in the exact mirror image: their 2 go on the 1-point (from their perspective, the 24-point), their 5 on the 12-point, their 3 on the 17-point, and their 5 on the 19-point.

🕹️ **INTERACTIVE**
Caption: *Place the checkers: drag them to the correct starting positions.*
Designer note: Empty board with 15 checkers in a tray beside it. User drags checkers to points. Correct placements lock in with a visual confirmation (subtle green glow or checkmark). Incorrect placements gently bounce back. Show the 2-5-3-5 rule as a reference above the board. Once complete, show the full starting position from both players' perspectives.

Direction of Play and Movement Flow

Checkers move in a horseshoe path. You move from your opponent's home board (high-numbered points) through the outer boards and into your own home board (low-numbered points). Your opponent moves the opposite direction. The two players are always heading toward opposite ends of the board.

Equipment and Accessory Setup

Beyond the board and checkers, a standard setup includes:

Doubling cube: a six-faced marker showing the numbers 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, and 64. It starts centred on the bar with the 64 face up (representing a starting value of 1).

→ For how the cube works, see The Doubling Cube.

Two pairs of dice: one pair for each player.

Dice cups: one per player. In serious play, cups with a lip (a small ridge inside) help ensure a fair roll by preventing controlled throws.

Some sets include a scoreboard or score sheet, but those aren't required for play.

Common Setup Variations

The standard setup described above is used in most backgammon worldwide, but two popular variants change the starting arrangement:

Nackgammon: created by Nack Ballard. Moves one checker each from the 13-point and the 6-point to the 24-point, giving each player four back checkers instead of two. This creates more contact and longer games.

Acey-Deucey: a military variant where all checkers start off the board and are entered during play. The board begins empty.

FAQ

Is the home board on the left or right?
Either side works. The home board can be on the left or the right depending on the physical setup, lighting, or player preference. What matters is that both players agree on orientation before placing checkers. In online play, this is handled automatically.

How many checkers does each player start with?
Each player starts with exactly 15 checkers. They're placed in the 2-5-3-5 pattern across four points on the board.

How do you decide who goes first?
Each player rolls one die. The player with the higher number goes first using both dice (their own roll and their opponent's) as the opening move. Ties mean both players roll again.

Does it matter which color you play?
No. The two colors are functionally identical. Color is purely cosmetic and has no effect on gameplay, rules, or scoring.

Why are there 2 checkers on the 24-point?
Those two back checkers make things interesting from the very first roll. They're deep in the opponent's home board, which means they have the longest journey home. But they're not just sitting there. They can anchor your defence and give you a chance to hit opponents who leave blots nearby. That push and pull between your far-flung checkers and the rest of your army closer to home is a big part of what makes the opening game so rich.

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. How many points are on a backgammon board?
○ 12
◉ 24 ← Correct
○ 30

2. In the standard setup, how many checkers go on the 13-point?
○ 2
○ 3
◉ 5 ← Correct

3. Where does the doubling cube start?
○ On the 1-point
◉ Centred on the bar, showing 64 ← Correct
○ Off the board

BEGINNER · 9 min read

The Backgammon Doubling Cube

What the doubling cube is, how it works, and why it makes backgammon so much more interesting.

Let's talk about the doubling cube. It's the piece in your backgammon set that looks like a die but never gets rolled. A lot of players set it aside when they're starting out, and that's totally fine, but once you get comfortable with it, you'll wonder how you ever played without it. The cube controls the stakes of the game, and learning to use it opens up a whole new layer of backgammon that's genuinely fun.

Think of it this way: without the cube, you're playing checkers on a backgammon board. With it, every game has a moment where you look your opponent in the eye and say, "I like where I stand. Want to raise the stakes?" That's where things get exciting.

→ For a full glossary of cube-related terms, see Backgammon Glossary.

What Is the Doubling Cube?

The cube has six faces showing 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, and 64. The 64 face doubles as 1 (the starting value). The numbers represent the multiplier applied to the final score of the game. If the cube shows 4, a **gammon** (normally worth 2 points) is now worth 8.

The cube isn't random: it's a negotiating tool. It lets you say, in effect, "I believe I'm winning. Are you willing to play for higher stakes, or would you rather concede this game now?"

🖼️ **DIAGRAM**
Caption: *The doubling cube: faces, starting position, and how it moves.*
Designer note: Show the cube with all six faces visible (2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64). Then a three-panel sequence: (1) cube centred on bar showing 64/1 (no one owns it). (2) Player A turns cube to 2 and offers it. (3) Player B accepts, cube goes to their side showing 2 (they now own it). Clean, minimal arrows showing the flow.

Basic Rules and Mechanics

The cube starts centred on the bar with the 64 face up, meaning the game is worth 1 point. Both players have access to it.

At the start of your turn, before rolling, you can offer a double by turning the cube to the next value (1 to 2, 2 to 4, 4 to 8, and so on) and placing it in front of your opponent. They have two choices:

Take (accept): the game continues at the new stake, and the opponent gains ownership of the cube. Only the owner can offer the next double.

Drop (pass): the game ends immediately. The player who dropped loses the game at the previous stake value.

Once someone owns the cube, only they decide when to redouble. The opponent who was doubled can't double back until they own the cube again (by accepting a future redouble from the other side). This is a neat feature that keeps things orderly and gives the person who accepted real power over what happens next.

The Sequence of Play: Offering, Taking, and Dropping

Here's how a typical cube sequence plays out:

1. The game starts at 1. The cube sits in the centre.
2. Player A offers a double. The cube turns to 2.
3. Player B takes. The cube goes to Player B's side, showing 2.
4. Later, Player B offers a redouble. The cube turns to 4.
5. Player A takes. The cube goes to Player A's side, showing 4.

The game is now worth 4 points (before gammon or backgammon multipliers).

→ For how those multipliers combine, see How Scoring Works.

Why Use the Cube? (The Strategy of Risk)

Ending the game efficiently: if you're clearly winning, a double forces the opponent to either play for double stakes or concede. Either outcome rewards your advantage.

Protecting against gammons: if you're losing but the position isn't hopeless, taking a double means you lose only the cube value. Dropping avoids the risk of losing a gammon (which costs double that).

Putting your opponent to the test: the cube introduces pressure. Even in match play, offering a double forces the opponent to make a real-time evaluation on the spot. And here's the

thing: people make mistakes under that pressure. Using the cube well is one of the best ways to gain an edge.

Core Strategic Concepts for Beginners

Three ideas give you a starting framework for cube decisions. Don't worry about mastering all of these right away. Just getting familiar with them will already improve your game.

Woolsey's Law. Named after Kit Woolsey, one of the game's great thinkers. The principle: if you're not sure whether your opponent should take or drop, go ahead and double. Close decisions are where opponents make the most mistakes. By doubling, you force them into a tough choice, and that's a good place for you to be.

→ For the full doubling framework, see When to Double.

Market Losers. A **market loser** is a dice roll that improves your position so much that your opponent, who would take right now, would have to drop next turn. If several of your 36 possible rolls are market losers, you want to double now, before you "lose your market." This clicks fast once you start looking for it in your games.

→ For market losers and volatility in depth, see When to Double.

The 25% Rule. When someone doubles you, here's a handy way to think about it: if your chance of winning the game is above 25%, taking is better than dropping in the long run. You're risking 1 point (the current stake) to play for 3 (your opponent's 2 points plus your 1 at the new stake). At 25% win probability, the risk and reward balance exactly. Below 25%, drop. Above 25%, take. You don't need to calculate this precisely. Just ask yourself, "Can I win roughly one time in four from here?"

→ For take points, cash points, and match adjustments, see When to Double.

Analyzing "Cube Action" Scenarios

The Race. When contact is broken and both sides are racing home, the **pip count** drives the cube decision. A handy guideline is the 8-9-12 rule: an 8% pip lead puts you in doubling range, 9% makes it a correct double in most positions, and 12% means the opponent is right on the edge of a take.

→ For counting methods, see Pip Counting.

The Blitz. When the opponent has checkers on the bar and your home board is closing, the position is volatile. One roll changes everything. Go ahead and double early in blitz positions, because waiting risks losing the window entirely.

The Prime. When you have opponent checkers trapped behind a wall of consecutive points, the question becomes whether to play on for the gammon. If your prime is strong and the opponent is collapsing, the expected value of playing for a gammon can be higher than the guaranteed point from a drop. This is the "too good to double" concept, so don't stress this yet. It comes up more in later articles.

→ For a full breakdown of these scenarios with examples, see Reading the Position.

Money Play vs. Match Play: How Context Changes Things

The setting you're playing in changes how you use the cube. Let's break it down.

Money Play. In casual or club play for stakes, the **Jacoby Rule** is common: gammons and backgammons don't count unless the cube has been turned. This encourages early doubling, because without turning the cube, those extra wins are worthless.

You might also run into **beavers** and raccoons, which are money play conventions you'll pick up at the club. A beaver means the opponent immediately redoubles after taking, but keeps ownership of the cube. A raccoon is a redouble of a beaver. They're basically a way to punish someone who doubles too aggressively. Don't worry about memorizing these right now. They'll make sense when you see them in action.

Match Play. In tournament or match play, the score changes everything. A player trailing badly doubles on the first roll of every game because they need to catch up fast. A player one point from victory plays conservatively because losing a doubled game would be a big setback.

The **Crawford Rule**: when one player is exactly one point from winning the match, the next game is played without the doubling cube. After the Crawford game, the trailing player doubles at the first opportunity every time.

You'll sometimes hear people mention match equity tables (METs), which are charts that show your probability of winning the match at every possible score. They're a great reference as you get deeper into match play, and you'll gradually learn to use them. For now, just know they exist and that they help guide cube decisions based on the score.

→ For scoring rules and the Crawford Rule in detail, see How Scoring Works.

Common Myths and Mistakes

"The cube is just luck." This is the most common misconception. The cube is actually where skill has the most leverage. When you check the numbers, cube decisions account for a larger share of overall error than checker play decisions in typical games.

Waiting for certainty. New players wait until they're "sure" before doubling. By that point, the opponent drops every time, and the doubler collects 1 point instead of playing for 2. The best doubles are the uncomfortable ones, and that's something every good player will tell you.

"I was doubled twice." A misunderstanding of the rules. Once a player accepts a double, only they can offer the next one. The cube doesn't bounce back and forth on the same turn.

Types of Doubling Cubes. Standard cubes are included with most backgammon sets and are functional for all play. Precision cubes have rounded edges for faster, more satisfying rotation. Collector and tournament cubes use materials like bone, stone, or heavy resin. The cube's physical form doesn't affect gameplay, but a well-made cube with clear numbers and satisfying weight is part of the experience.

FAQ

What do the numbers on the doubling cube mean?
The numbers (2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64) represent the multiplier applied to the game's final score. At the start, the cube shows 64, which counts as 1. Each time a player doubles, the multiplier moves to the next value. If the cube shows 8, a single win is worth 8 points, a gammon is worth 16, and a backgammon is worth 24.

Can you double on the first move?
Yes, but the first move has a special rule: both players roll one die to determine who goes first, and the winner plays that roll immediately. Since doubling happens before rolling, you can't double on the very first turn. Starting from the second turn onward, either player can double (if the cube is still centred) or the cube owner can redouble.

What happens if I reject a double?
The game ends immediately. You lose the game at the current stake value (before the proposed double). For example, if the cube is at 1 and your opponent doubles to 2, rejecting means you lose 1 point. This is often the right play when your winning chances are below 25%.

Who controls the cube after a double?
The player who accepted the double gains ownership. Only the cube owner can offer the next double. This keeps things orderly: it prevents players from doubling back and forth every turn.

Is the doubling cube used in all backgammon games?
Not always. Casual games often skip the cube entirely, and that's a perfectly good way to learn the basics. In competitive play (both money games and tournament matches), the cube is standard. Some specific match situations also remove the cube: the Crawford game is played without it, and at DMP (Double Match Point, when both players need just 1 point), the cube doesn't matter because there's nothing left to double for.

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. What does the 64 on the cube represent at the start of the game?
○ 64 points
◉ A value of 1 (the starting stake) ← Correct
○ The maximum number of doubles allowed

2. What is a beaver in money play?
○ A rule that prevents doubling on the first turn
◉ An immediate redouble by the player who was just doubled, keeping the cube ← Correct
○ A penalty for doubling too aggressively

3. The 25% rule says that if your win probability is above 25%, you:
○ Always double
◉ Take the double ← Correct
○ Wait for a better position

BEGINNER · 6 min read

How Backgammon Scoring Works

How wins, gammons, backgammons, and the doubling cube combine to produce a final score.

Backgammon scoring has a few layers to it, but once you see how they fit together, it clicks. A simple win earns 1 point. A gammon doubles it. A backgammon triples it. The doubling cube multiplies everything again. Knowing how these layers stack up is the difference between knowing who won and knowing what the win was actually worth.

→ For definitions of every scoring term, see Backgammon Glossary.

The Objective: How to Win a Game

The objective is to bear off all 15 of your checkers before your opponent does. The first player to clear the board wins the game.

But not all wins are equal. How much you win by depends on two things: how badly your opponent was losing when you finished, and the value on the **doubling cube**. Picture this: a single game that ends with the cube at 8 is worth more than a gammon with the cube at 1. That's why scoring in backgammon isn't just arithmetic; it shapes the way you play.

The Three Levels of Victory: Single, Gammon, and Backgammon

A **single game** (also called a plain win) earns **1 point**. The loser has borne off at least one checker.

A **gammon** earns **2 points**. The loser hasn't borne off a single checker. This is the most common "bonus" result and it happens more often than most players expect. In many games, the decision to play on for a gammon or cash the win with a double is one of the most important choices you'll face.

A **backgammon** earns **3 points**. The loser hasn't borne off any checkers and still has a checker in the winner's home board or on the bar. This is rare but devastating.

🖼️ **DIAGRAM**
(Caption: Gammon and backgammon victories illustrated on the board.)
Designer note: Two side-by-side mini-boards showing end-of-game positions. (1) Gammon: winner's board cleared, opponent has all 15 checkers still on the board (but all in their home board or outer board).

(2) Backgammon: winner's board cleared, opponent still has checkers on the bar or in the winner's home board. Label each clearly.

The Doubling Cube: Multiplying the Stakes

The doubling cube multiplies the base value of the win. If the cube shows 4 and you win a gammon, the score is 4 x 2 = 8 points.

The formula: **Final Score = (Base Win Value) x (Cube Value).**

Base win values: Single = 1, Gammon = 2, Backgammon = 3. The cube value starts at 1 and doubles each time a player turns it (2, 4, 8, 16, and so on). So a backgammon with the cube at 4 is worth 12 points. At higher cube values, these numbers climb fast, which is exactly why cube decisions matter so much.

→ For how the cube works, see The Doubling Cube.

Scoring Contexts: Match Play vs. Money Play

Match play means you're racing to a target score (first to 5, 7, 11, or any agreed number). The match score shapes how aggressively or carefully you play. When you need one point to win, every game matters equally regardless of gammons. When you're trailing, gammon wins become more valuable because they help you catch up faster.

The **Crawford Rule**: once a player reaches one point away from winning the match, the following game is played without the doubling cube. This prevents the trailing player from immediately doubling to catch up. After the Crawford game, the cube is back in play and the trailing player doubles at the first opportunity.

→ For cube strategy in match play, see When to Double.

Money play means every point is worth the same real or notional amount. There's no match score. Gammons and backgammons always count at full value (unless the **Jacoby Rule** is in effect, which requires the cube to be turned before gammons count). In money sessions, steady and accurate play pays off over the long run because there's no finish line, and every point counts equally.

Pip Counting: Tracking the Board State

The **pip count** isn't part of the scoreboard (unless you're playing online, where games like backgammon.com display it automatically), but it tracks the state of the race on the board. Each checker's pip count equals the point number it sits on. Add up all 15 of your checkers and you've got your total distance to bearing off.

The player with the lower pip count is winning the race. This number drives cube decisions and strategic choices throughout the game. Knowing your pip count and your opponent's tells you whether to double, whether to take, and whether to play for contact or race. Don't worry if counting pips feels awkward at first. It gets easier with practice, and there are shortcuts to help.

→ For counting methods and doubling formulas, see Pip Counting.

→ For how bearing off works once you get there, see Bearing Off.

FAQ

How many points is a backgammon worth compared to a gammon?
A backgammon is worth 3 points (before the cube multiplier), while a gammon is worth 2 points. A backgammon is 1.5 times the value of a gammon. Both values are then multiplied by the current cube value.

What happens if I refuse a double?
The game ends immediately. You lose the game at the current stake (before the proposed double). If the cube was at 1, you lose 1 point. If the cube was at 4, you lose 4 points. Dropping is the right play when your winning chances are too low to justify continuing at double the stakes.

Why are there numbers like 64 on the doubling cube?
The doubling cube shows powers of 2: 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, and 64. Each face represents the next level of doubling. The 64 face also serves as the starting value of 1 (before any doubles have been offered). In theory, the cube can keep doubling beyond 64, but in practice games rarely reach that level.

What is the Crawford Rule?
When one player is exactly one point away from winning a match, the next game is played without the doubling cube. This is the Crawford game. It exists to prevent the trailing player from doubling on the first turn of every game to force a coin-flip finish. After the Crawford game, the cube returns and the trailing player doubles immediately in every subsequent game.

Do you have to bear off exactly?
No. If you roll a number higher than the point where your highest checker sits, you bear off that checker. For example, if your highest checker is on the 4-point and you roll a 6, you bear off from the 4-point. You don't need an exact roll to remove a checker.

→ *For the complete bearing off rules, see Bearing Off.*

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. If the cube shows 4 and you win a single game, how many points do you score?
○ 2
◉ 4 ← Correct
○ 8

2. If the cube shows 8 and you win a backgammon, how many points do you score?
○ 8
○ 16
◉ 24 ← Correct

3. In money play, the Jacoby Rule means:
○ The doubling cube starts at 2
◉ Gammons and backgammons only count if the cube has been turned ← Correct
○ You cannot double on the first turn

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Backgammon Glossary

Every term you'll encounter, organised by category.

This glossary covers the terms you'll hear at the table, read in strategy guides, and see in software analysis. Terms are grouped by function rather than listed alphabetically, so related concepts sit next to each other and make more sense together.

If a term has its own dedicated article, there's a link. For everything else, the definition here is all you need.

Board Geography and Setup Terms

Point: one of the 24 narrow triangles on the board. Checkers sit on points.
→ See Board Setup Explained for the full board layout.

Bar: the raised strip dividing the board in half. Checkers that get hit are placed here.
→ See Hitting vs Playing Safe for how the bar affects strategy.

Home board: points 1–6. The section where you bear off.
→ See Bearing Off for the rules of the final phase.

Outer board: points 7–12. The section between the midpoint and your home board.

Midpoint: the 13-point. Five of your checkers start here.
→ See Board Setup Explained for the starting position.

Pip: the unit of distance on the board. Moving from the 8-point to the 5-point is a move of 3 pips.
→ See Pip Counting for how to track the race.

Golden Point: the 5-point (your own or your opponent's). Widely considered the most valuable point to make in the early game because of its blocking power and bearing-off efficiency.
→ See Building a Prime for why key points matter.

Gameplay Mechanics and Movement Definitions

Blot: a single checker on a point. Vulnerable to being hit.
→ See Hitting vs Playing Safe for when to leave blots and when to play safe.

Hit: landing on an opponent's blot, sending it to the bar.
→ See Hitting vs Playing Safe for the full hitting rules.

Enter / Come in: bringing a checker from the bar into the opponent's home board.

Fanning / Dancing: failing to enter from the bar because all required points are blocked. Not a fun experience.

Closed board: all six home board points occupied by your checkers. An opponent on the bar can't enter.

Bearing off: removing checkers from the board during the final phase of the game.
→ See Bearing Off for rules, edge cases, and technique.

Scoring Terminology and Win Conditions

Single game: a win worth 1 point. The opponent bore off at least one checker.

Gammon: a win worth 2 points. The opponent didn't bear off any checkers.
→ See How Scoring Works for how gammon value interacts with the cube.

Backgammon: a win worth 3 points. The opponent hasn't borne off and still has a checker on the bar or in the winner's home board.
→ See How Scoring Works for the full scoring formula.

Match play: playing to a set target score (e.g., first to 7 points).
→ See How Scoring Works for match play vs. money play differences.

Money play: each game is scored independently for stakes.

The Doubling Cube Dictionary

Doubling cube: a marker (not rolled) showing 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64. Controls the game's stake multiplier.

→ See The Doubling Cube for the full explanation.

Take / Accept: agreeing to continue at the new doubled stake.

Drop / Pass: declining the double and conceding the game at the current stake.

Redouble: offering a new double when you own the cube (after having previously accepted a double).

Beaver: a money play rule allowing the player who was doubled to immediately redouble while keeping the cube. Basically saying, "I think your double was a mistake, so let's play for more."
→ See The Doubling Cube for beaver and raccoon rules.

Crawford Rule: in match play, when one player is 1 point from victory, the next game is played without the cube.
→ See How Scoring Works for how the Crawford Rule affects match strategy.

Jacoby Rule: in money play, gammons and backgammons don't count unless the cube has been turned at least once.
→ See The Doubling Cube for money play conventions.

Strategic Concepts and Game Plans

Anchor: a made point in the opponent's home board. Your safe landing spot and launchpad for counterattacks.
→ See Holding Game for anchor-based strategies.

Builder: a spare checker positioned to help make a new point on a future roll.

Slot: placing a blot on a point you want to make, hoping to cover it next turn.

Cover: adding a second checker to a blot, converting it into a made point.

Prime: a series of consecutive made points that block the opponent's movement.
→ See Building a Prime for how to construct and maintain primes.

Blitz: an attacking strategy focused on hitting opponent checkers and closing home board points to prevent re-entry.
→ See Hitting vs Playing Safe for blitz timing.

Running game: a strategy of racing to bear off first, typically chosen when you're leading in the pip count.
→ See Pip Counting for how to evaluate race positions.

Holding game: maintaining an anchor in the opponent's board and waiting for a chance to hit.

Back game: a defensive strategy using multiple anchors deep in the opponent's board, waiting for a late-game shot.

Timing: having enough productive moves remaining to maintain your position without being forced to break key points. Think of it as fuel in the tank: when you run out, your position starts falling apart.

Crunching: being forced to break your own points because you've run out of useful moves. This is what happens when your timing runs dry.

Dice, Probability, and Math Lingo

Direct shot: a blot within 6 points of an opponent checker. Can be hit with a single die.

Indirect shot: a blot 7 or more points away. Requires both dice to combine for the hit.

Duplication: here's a neat idea: you arrange your checkers so the opponent needs the same number to do two different things. Since they can only use each die once, this cuts down their good rolls. For example, if they need a 4 to both escape and hit, fewer rolls let them do both.

Joker: a lucky roll that dramatically changes the game.

Market loser: a roll so strong that it swings the cube decision from "opponent takes" to "opponent drops."
→ See When to Double for how market losers drive cube timing.

Pip count: the total distance (in pips) that a player's checkers must travel to bear off. Lower is better.
→ See Pip Counting for counting methods and race formulas.

Gin: a position where one player has already won and the remaining rolls are a formality. The outcome is determined. Named by analogy with gin rummy.

Tournament Play and Chouette Slang

Chouette: a multi-player format where one player (the box) plays against a team led by a captain. Rotation happens after wins.

DMP (Double Match Point): both players need exactly 1 point to win. Gammons don't matter and the cube is irrelevant.
→ See How Scoring Works for match play scoring rules.

GG (Gammon Go): a match score where winning a gammon wins the match but losing a gammon doesn't end it. Encourages aggressive play.

GS (Gammon Save): a match score where being gammoned costs the match. Encourages conservative play.

PR (Performance Rating): a measure of average error per decision. Lower is better. This is the number players use to track how well they're playing over time.

Match equity table (MET): a chart showing each player's probability of winning a match at every possible score. Used to make precise cube decisions in match play.
→ See When to Double for how METs guide cube strategy.

FAQ

What is the difference between a gammon and a backgammon?
A gammon (2 points) means the loser didn't bear off any checkers. A backgammon (3 points) means the loser didn't bear off any checkers and still has at least one checker on the bar or in the winner's home board. The backgammon is rarer and more punishing.

What is the Crawford Rule?
When one player is exactly one point from winning a match, the next game is played without the doubling cube. This is the Crawford game. It stops the trailing player from immediately doubling to force a coin-flip situation. After the Crawford game, the cube returns to play.

What is a beaver in backgammon?
A beaver is a money play convention. When your opponent doubles, you can "beaver" by immediately redoubling the cube to the next value while keeping ownership. It's a way of saying "your double was a mistake, and I want to play for even higher stakes." Beavers aren't used in match play.

What does "gin" mean in backgammon?

Gin refers to a position where the outcome is already locked in. One player has effectively won, and the remaining rolls are just going through the motions. The term is borrowed from gin rummy.

Why is the 5-point called the Golden Point?
The 5-point (either your own or your opponent's) is considered the single most valuable point to own early in the game. Your own 5-point anchors your home board, contributes to a prime, and helps with bearing off efficiency. Your opponent's 5-point gives you a strong defensive anchor. Making the 5-point early is almost always a priority.

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. What is a blot?
○ A blocked point
◉ A single checker on a point, vulnerable to being hit ← Correct
○ A checker on the bar

2. What is a market loser?
○ A roll that loses you the game immediately
◉ A roll so strong it swings the cube decision from "opponent takes" to "opponent drops" ← Correct
○ A situation where neither player can double

3. What does DMP stand for?
○ Double My Points
◉ Double Match Point ← Correct
○ Doubling Multiplier Position

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Backgammon's 5 Core Strategies

The five game plans every player needs to recognise, choose between, and execute.

Every position in backgammon points toward one of five basic strategies. Recognising which one fits your current game is the first step to making better decisions. You don't pick a strategy before the game starts: the dice and the board tell you which way to go. Your job is to read the situation and go with it.

The good news? You don't need to master all five at once. Just knowing they exist will change how you see the board.

→ For every term in this article defined in one place, see Backgammon Glossary.

Essential Backgammon Terminology

Before we get into the five strategies, here are the key terms worth knowing:

Blot: a single checker sitting alone on a point. It can be hit by the opponent.

Anchor: a point in the opponent's home board where you have two or more checkers. Anchors give you a safe re-entry point and a base for counterattack.

Prime: a wall of consecutive made points that blocks the opponent's checkers from advancing. A full prime (six points in a row) is impassable.

Pip count: the total number of points your checkers need to travel to bear off. The player with the lower pip count is ahead in the race.

Gammon: a win where the losing player has not borne off any checkers. Worth double the stake.

→ For a complete list of terms, see Backgammon Glossary.

Strategy 1: The Running Game (Racing)

The simplest strategy: race home and bear off before the opponent does. The running game applies when you're ahead in the pip count and contact between the two sides is broken or nearly broken.

When to run: your pip count leads by a comfortable margin (roughly 10% or more), and the opponent has no good chance of hitting you.

How to execute: avoid leaving blots. Move your checkers toward home as efficiently as possible. Break contact where you can. In a race, every pip matters.

When the running game is active, the doubling cube becomes critical. A pip count lead in a race is the clearest situation for cube decisions.

→ For doubling math in racing positions, see When to Double.

→ For how to calculate and track pip counts, see Pip Counting.

🖼️ **DIAGRAM**
Caption: *A running game: both sides have broken contact and are racing home.*
Designer note: Board position where both players have all checkers past each other with no contact possible. One player has a clear pip count lead. Label the pip counts for both sides. Highlight the path each player's checkers will take to their home board.

Strategy 2: The Blitz (Attacking)

A blitz is an all-out attacking strategy. The goal is to hit the opponent's checkers, trap them on the bar, and close your home board before they can re-enter. A successful blitz wins gammons.

When to blitz: the opponent has exposed blots in or near your home board, and you have builders ready to close points.

How to execute: hit every chance you get. Make home board points. Don't worry about leaving your own blots in the process: a blitz is high-risk, high-reward, and hesitating usually costs more than committing.

If the blitz stalls (the opponent anchors or you run out of builders), the game often transitions into a priming game. The points you made during the attack become a wall that traps the opponent's checkers. So even a blitz that doesn't finish the job can leave you in great shape.

→ For the hitting framework, see Hitting vs Playing Safe.

🕹️ **INTERACTIVE**
Caption: *Build the last point of a 6-prime: drag a checker to complete the wall.*
Designer note: Board showing a 5-point prime (points 2 through 6 made, or points 3 through 7) with one gap remaining. The player has a builder in range. Display a dice roll that allows closing the prime. The user drags the builder to the open point to complete the 6-prime. On success, show a brief explanation of why a full prime is impassable.

Strategy 3: The Priming Game (Blocking)

A priming game builds a wall of consecutive made points (called a prime) that traps the opponent's back checkers. The larger the prime (up to a maximum of six points in a row), the harder it is for the opponent to escape.

When to prime: you have the opponent's checkers stuck behind two or three of your made points, and you have builders available to extend the wall.

How to execute: secure key points (the 5-point and the bar point are the most valuable) and extend the prime one point at a time. Keep your back checkers safe while building the front. As the prime grows, the opponent's options shrink until they're forced into bad moves.

Walking the prime means advancing the wall toward your home board while keeping it intact. You break the rearmost point and use those checkers to make a new point at the front. It takes a bit of practice, but it's one of the most satisfying things in the game.

→ For a full breakdown of building and walking a prime, see Building a Prime.

→ For which points to prioritize, see Making Points.

Strategy 4: The Holding Game (Defensive)

A holding game is a defensive strategy built around maintaining an advanced anchor (a made point in the opponent's home board, ideally the 20-point or 21-point). You hold the anchor, stay in the game, and wait for a shot.

When to hold: you're behind in the race but have a strong anchor. The opponent will eventually have to move past your anchor, giving you a chance to hit.

How to execute: maintain the anchor as long as possible while bearing your other checkers in safely. When the opponent is forced to break past your anchor, look for the hitting opportunity that changes the game.

The holding game is steady and patient. It doesn't usually create gammon chances, but it keeps you alive in games where you're behind. Think of it like playing solid defence and waiting for your opponent to make a mistake, and sometimes that's exactly the right approach.

🕹️ **INTERACTIVE**
Caption: *Name that strategy: look at the board and pick which game plan fits.*
Designer note: Show 3 board positions one at a time. For each, the user selects from a list of the five strategies. After choosing, reveal the correct answer with a one-sentence explanation. Use positions that clearly illustrate a running game, a blitz, and a priming game.

Strategy 5: The Back Game (Deep Defense)

The back game is the most extreme defensive strategy. You hold two or more anchors deep in the opponent's home board (typically on the 1, 2, or 3-points) and wait for the opponent to expose a blot as they bear in. Then you hit it.

When to play a back game: you're far behind in the race, you've been hit multiple times, and your only realistic path to winning involves hitting a late shot.

How to execute: keep your anchors intact. Maintain your own home board for as long as possible (this is called timing) so that when you hit, the opponent re-enters into a strong board and can't recover. The back game fails when your timing runs out and your board collapses before the shot appears.

Developing a Game Plan: How to Choose?

You don't choose a strategy the way you pick a play from a playbook. The position tells you. The pip count, the checker distribution, and the dice guide the choice.

Most games start with general development: splitting, building, and fighting for key points. The strategy becomes clearer as the game progresses. Take a look at the position, figure out which plan makes sense, and go with it. You won't always get it right at first, and that's completely fine. The more games you play, the faster you'll recognise which strategy the board is pointing you toward.

→ For the full position-reading framework, see Reading the Position.

→ For the math behind racing decisions, see Pip Counting.

FAQ

What is the most aggressive backgammon strategy?
The blitz. It aims to hit the opponent's checkers repeatedly, trap them on the bar, and close your home board before they can re-enter. A successful blitz often wins a gammon.

How do I know which strategy to use?
The position tells you. Check the pip count, look at where the checkers are, and see what the dice allow. If you're ahead in the race with no contact, run. If the opponent has blots in your home board, blitz. If you have consecutive points trapping their checkers, prime. If you're behind with a good anchor, hold. If you're far behind with deep anchors, play a back game.

What is the difference between a holding game and a back game?
A holding game uses one advanced anchor (the 20-point or 21-point) to wait for a shot while racing the rest of your checkers home. A back game uses two or more deep anchors (the 1, 2, or 3-points) and relies entirely on hitting a late shot. The back game is riskier and is typically a last resort when you're far behind.

When to double in a running game?
In a pure race, the pip count guides your cube decisions. A common rule of thumb: if your pip count lead is roughly 8% or more, consider doubling. Your opponent takes if they're not too far behind. The exact thresholds depend on pip count size and checker distribution.

How do you counter a blitz?
Anchor. Your top priority is making a point in the attacker's home board (the 4-point or 5-point are strongest). Once you've got an anchor, the blitz loses its power because you've got a safe re-entry point. From there, you can stabilize and look for counterplay.

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. In a running game, what is your primary concern?
○ Building a prime
◉ Minimising pip wastage and racing home efficiently ← Correct
○ Hitting the opponent as often as possible

2. A blitz that stalls often transitions into:
○ A back game
◉ A priming game ← Correct
○ A running game

3. The holding game is built around:
○ Building a 6-point prime
◉ Maintaining an advanced anchor and waiting for a shot ← Correct
○ Hitting opponent checkers repeatedly

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Best Backgammon Opening Moves

What to play with each of the 15 opening rolls, and why those moves are strongest.

Here's the good news: the opening is the one part of backgammon where the bots all agree on the right play. For each of the 15 possible opening rolls, there's a best move, and it's the same whether you're playing for pennies or in a world championship final.

That doesn't mean you should just memorize a chart and move on. Understanding why each move is strongest helps you make better decisions for the rest of the game. And once you know these 15 moves, you'll feel more confident from the very first roll.

→ For every term in this article defined in one place, see Backgammon Glossary.

The Basics of the Opening Roll

Each player rolls one die. The higher number goes first, using both dice. Doubles can't occur on the opening roll because each player contributes one die. This creates 15 distinct opening rolls (all combinations of two different numbers from 1 to 6).

The notation works like this: "3-1" means you rolled a 3 and a 1 on the dice. "8/5" means move a checker from the 8-point to the 5-point. Each dice roll tells you which numbers to play, and the notation tells you which checkers move where.

The "Big 5": The Best Opening Moves

The strongest opening rolls are the ones that immediately make a new point. A made point is permanent structure: it blocks the opponent and gives you a safe landing spot for future moves. Picture this: you roll 3-1 on the very first turn, and just like that, you own the most valuable real estate on the board. That's the kind of head start these rolls give you.

→ For why making points is the foundation of every strategy, see Making Points.

Dice roll 3-1: Make the 5-Point (8/5, 6/5)
The best opening roll in backgammon. The 5-point is the most valuable point on the board. Making it immediately gives you a strong home board anchor and blocks the opponent's back checkers.

Dice roll 6-1: Make the Bar Point (13/7, 8/7)
The bar point (7-point) connects your outer board to your home board. Making it starts a potential prime and blocks the opponent from escaping with a 6.

Dice roll 4-2: Make the 4-Point (8/4, 6/4)
Less valuable than the 5-point or bar point, but still a made point. It strengthens the home board and contributes to a future prime.

Dice roll 5-3: Make the 3-Point (8/3, 6/3)
The weakest of the point-making openings. The 3-point is deep in your home board, which makes it less useful for blocking in the early game. Still better than most non-point-making alternatives.

Dice roll 6-5: Lover's Leap (24/13)
Not a point-making move, but the best use of a large roll. Running one back checker all the way to the midpoint escapes it from danger in one move. This classic opening is called the Lover's Leap because it leaps a back runner to safety in a single bound.

🕹️ **INTERACTIVE**
Caption: *Play the 3-1 opening: drag your checkers to make the 5-point.*
Designer note: Board in starting position with the dice roll 3-1 displayed. The user drags a checker from the 8-point to the 5-point and another from the 6-point to the 5-point. On success, highlight the newly made 5-point and show a one-line explanation of why this is the best opening roll.

Strategic Concepts: Splitting vs. Slotting

For the remaining 10 rolls, the debate centres on two approaches:

Splitting the back runners: moving one of your back checkers forward (usually from the 24-point to the opponent's 4 or 5-point). This diversifies your position and fights for an anchor in the opponent's board. Splitting is the safer approach and creates more future options.

Slotting the 5-point (or another key point): moving a checker to a point you want to make, even though it leaves a blot. If you cover it next turn, you've made a valuable point. If you get hit, you lose a tempo. Slotting is the more aggressive alternative and works best when you're willing to accept a hit in exchange for a shot at making a strong point.

The bots all agree: splitting is usually the better choice. It's lower risk and creates more options. The trade-off is real though: keeping all your checkers bunched on safe points feels secure, but it wastes development. Splitting puts your checkers where they can actually fight for key territory.

→ *For more on the risk/reward trade-off, see Hitting vs Playing Safe.*

How to Play the "Other" Common Rolls

Split-and-Down Rolls (dice rolls 2-1, 4-1, 5-1)
Split one of your back checkers forward (usually to the opponent's 4 or 5-point) and bring a builder down from the midpoint. This fights on two fronts at once: escaping the back and developing the front.

Two-Way Moves (dice rolls 3-2, 4-3, 5-2, 5-4)
These rolls offer moves that advance a back checker and bring a builder into your outer board. Some give you a choice between splitting and slotting. The bots tend to lean toward splitting for most of them.

Running Rolls (dice rolls 6-4, 6-3, 6-2)
The large die number suggests running. A 6-4 escapes a back checker all the way to the opponent's outer board. A 6-3 and 6-2 typically use the 6 to run and the smaller number to develop a builder.

Understanding opening replies (your response to the opponent's first move) follows the same logic. The principles of splitting, slotting, and point-making apply on your second turn too, with the added information of where the opponent placed their checkers.

→ For how these openings connect to broader game plans, see 5 Core Strategies.

Backgammon Opening Rolls Chart (Cheat Sheet)

A reference for all 15 opening rolls, grouped by type:

Point-making rolls:
Dice roll 3-1: 8/5, 6/5 (make the 5-point)
Dice roll 4-2: 8/4, 6/4 (make the 4-point)
Dice roll 6-1: 13/7, 8/7 (make the bar point)
Dice roll 5-3: 8/3, 6/3 (make the 3-point)

Action rolls (splitting and developing):
Dice roll 6-5: 24/13 (Lover's Leap)
Dice roll 2-1: 13/11, 24/23
Dice roll 4-1: 13/9, 24/23
Dice roll 5-1: 13/8, 24/23
Dice roll 3-2: 13/11, 24/21
Dice roll 4-3: 13/10, 24/20

Dice roll 5-2: 13/11, 24/22
Dice roll 5-4: 13/8, 24/20

Running rolls:
Dice roll 6-4: 24/14
Dice roll 6-3: 24/15
Dice roll 6-2: 24/18, 13/11

→ For doubling strategy after the opening, see The Doubling Cube.

Opening Strategy: Money Play vs. Match Play

The standard moves listed above are correct for money play. In match play, the match score can shift your priorities. When you need a gammon (known as a gammon-go situation), aggressive plays like slotting become more attractive because the extra risk is worth the chance at double points. When you need to avoid being gammoned (a gammon-save situation), safe plays gain value. For most situations, the standard openings remain correct.

FAQ

What is the best opening move in backgammon?
The dice roll 3-1, played as 8/5, 6/5 to make the 5-point. The 5-point is the most valuable point on the board, and making it on the first roll gives you an immediate structural advantage. No other opening roll comes close.

Why can't you roll doubles on the opening roll?
Because each player rolls one die, not two. You each contribute a single die to determine who goes first, so the two numbers are always different. Once the game is underway, each player rolls both of their own dice and doubles become possible.

For beginners, split or slot?
Split. Splitting is lower risk and creates useful options on future turns. Slotting is the more aggressive play: it pays off when you cover the blot next turn, but it costs you when the opponent hits it. If you're still getting comfortable with the game, go with splitting. It's the more reliable approach, and you can always add slotting to your toolkit later.

What is Lover's Leap?
Lover's Leap is the name for the 6-5 opening move: 24/13. You run one back checker from the opponent's home board all the way to the midpoint in a single move. It's the only opening roll that escapes a back checker completely in one turn.

How do you memorize backgammon opening moves?
Start with the Big 5 (the rolls that make a point or run to the midpoint). For the other 10 rolls, learn the pattern: split a back checker and bring a builder down. The chart in this article covers all 15 rolls. Try learning a few at a time. Once you understand the logic behind each move, they stick much better than rote memorization.

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. Why can't doubles occur on the opening roll?
○ It is against the rules to start with doubles
◉ Each player rolls one die, so the two numbers are always different ← Correct
○ Doubles are rerolled until a non-double appears

2. What does the notation 8/5 mean?
○ Roll an 8 and a 5
◉ Move a checker from the 8-point to the 5-point ← Correct
○ Make both the 8-point and the 5-point

3. For non-point-making opening rolls, what is the general pattern?
○ Always run your back checkers
◉ Split a back checker forward and bring a builder down ← Correct
○ Stack more checkers on the 6-point

BEGINNER · 6 min read

Backgammon: Making Points

What making a point means, why it's the foundation of every strategy, and which points are worth fighting for.

If there's one thing that ties all of backgammon together, it's this: which points do you control? Making points gives you safe positions for your own checkers, restricts your opponent's movement, and builds the structures that win games. Get comfortable with this idea and everything else starts to click.

→ For every term in this article defined in one place, see Backgammon Glossary.

What Does Making a Point Mean?

When you place two or more of your checkers on the same triangle, you've made that point. Your opponent can't land on it. It's blocked to them and safe for you.

A single checker on a point (a blot) is vulnerable to being hit. Adding a second checker to a blot converts it into a made point. This transition is called covering the blot.

Why Making Points Wins Games

There are three big reasons why controlling points is so valuable:

Board control: every point you own is space your opponent can't use. The more points you make, the fewer options they have.

Safety: made points are safe landing spots. Your checkers can move through the board without risk of being hit on those points.

Blocking: adjacent made points form a prime that traps opponent checkers completely. Four, five, or six points in a row create a wall that nothing can pass.

→ For how to build and maintain a prime, see Building a Prime.

The Hierarchy of Points: Which Ones Matter Most?

Not all points are equally valuable. Some are worth significant risk to make. Others are useful but not worth a fight.

The 5-Point (The Golden Point)
The most valuable point on the board. Making your own 5-point strengthens your home board offensively (it's a powerful block against escaping checkers) and provides the best anchor position defensively. The opening roll of 3-1 makes the 5-point, and it's the best first roll in the game for exactly this reason.

The Bar Point (7-Point)
The bar point bridges your outer board and your home board. Making it blocks the opponent's back checkers from escaping and starts building a prime. The 6-1 opening roll makes the bar point, and combined with the 5-point it creates the beginning of a serious wall.

The Golden Anchor (Opponent's 5-Point)
The opponent's 5-point (the 20-point from your perspective) is the strongest defensive anchor in the game. Holding it guarantees re-entry from the bar if you get hit, and it gives you a base for a holding game where you wait for a shot.

→ For all 15 opening rolls and which points they make, see Best Opening Moves.

🕹️ **INTERACTIVE**
Caption: *Make the point: use the dice roll to cover a blot and secure the position.*
Designer note: Board position with a blot on the player's 5-point and builders in range. Display a dice roll that allows covering the blot. The user drags the correct checker to the 5-point to make it. On success, highlight the newly made point and show a one-line explanation of why the 5-point is the most valuable point on the board. Offer a second round with the bar point.

Tactics for Making Points

Using Builders and Flexibility

Builders are checkers positioned where they can reach the point you want to make on the next roll. The more builders you have in range of a target point, the more dice combinations will let you make it.

Spreading your checkers across different points maximises your useful rolls. Stacking too many checkers on a single point (sometimes called candlesticks) is a common trap. Those extras are just sitting there doing nothing. Think of it like having five people crammed into a phone booth when they could be out covering the field.

Slotting vs. Safety Play

Slotting means deliberately placing a blot on a point you want to make, hoping to cover it with a second checker on the next turn. It's the aggressive option: you risk getting hit, but if you cover, you've made a key point that changes the whole game.

When to slot: you're behind and need to build structure quickly, and the point you're targeting is valuable enough to justify the risk. **When to play safe:** you're ahead in the race and creating blots gives your opponent a free opportunity to get back into the game.

→ For more on the risk/reward framework, see Hitting vs Playing Safe.

Opening Moves That Make Points

Three opening rolls let you make a point right away, and they're the strongest openings for exactly that reason:

Dice roll 3-1: makes the 5-point
Dice roll 6-1: makes the bar point
Dice roll 4-2: makes the 4-point

→ For all 15 opening rolls, see Best Opening Moves.

Priming vs. Blitzing

Made points serve two different attacking strategies. **Priming** creates a wall of consecutive points to contain opponent checkers. **Blitzing** hits blots and closes home board points to keep the opponent on the bar. Here's a nice thing: even when a blitz stalls, those points you made during the attack often form a wall that traps the opponent's checkers. So your effort is never wasted.

→ For a full breakdown of both strategies and when each applies, see 5 Core Strategies.

FAQ

What is the most important point to make in backgammon?
The 5-point. It's the strongest point on the board for both offense and defense. Offensively, it blocks the opponent's back checkers from escaping through your home board. Defensively, it anchors your position. Making it on the first roll (with a 3-1) is the best opening in the game.

Is the 5-point or bar-point more important?
The 5-point. While the bar point is valuable for starting a prime and blocking escape routes, the 5-point is stronger because it serves double duty: it blocks the opponent and anchors your home board. That said, owning both creates one of the most powerful structures in the game.

When to break your anchor?
Break your anchor when the race favours you and you no longer need the defensive safety it provides. If you're ahead in the pip count and your opponent has passed your anchor, holding it no longer serves a purpose. At that point, release the checkers and use them to bear in efficiently.

What does "making a point" mean in backgammon?
Placing two or more of your checkers on the same triangle (point). Once you own a point, the opponent can't land on it. It becomes a safe position for your checkers and a barrier for theirs.

When is slotting the best strategy?
Slot when the target point is high-value (the 5-point or bar point), you're behind in the race and need to build structure fast, and the opponent's home board is weak (so getting hit isn't devastating). Avoid slotting when you're ahead in the race or when the opponent has a strong home board.

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. Why is stacking five or more checkers on a single point a problem?
○ The rules limit you to four checkers per point
◉ Extra checkers on one point are not helping you make new points or build a prime ← Correct
○ Stacked points can be captured by the opponent

2. What does covering a blot mean?
○ Moving a blot to a different point for safety
◉ Adding a second checker to a blot, making the point ← Correct
○ Hitting an opponent's blot

3. Which three opening rolls make a point immediately?
○ 6-5, 5-4, 4-3
◉ 3-1, 6-1, 4-2 ← Correct
○ 2-1, 3-2, 5-1

BEGINNER → INTERMEDIATE · 7 min read

Backgammon: Hitting vs Playing Safe

The core strategic trade-off in every game: when to attack, when to protect, and how to make the decision.

Every time you roll the dice, some moves hit. Some moves play safe. Some do both. Choosing between them is the most frequent decision in backgammon, and getting better at this one choice is the fastest way to improve your results.

Here's the thing to keep in mind: the goal is never simply to hit or simply to play safe. You're looking for the move that gives you the best winning chances from the current position forward. Sometimes that means hitting and accepting the risk of a return shot. Sometimes it means playing quietly and letting your positional advantage do the work. Don't worry if this feels tricky at first. It gets much more intuitive with practice.

→ For every term in this article defined in one place, see Backgammon Glossary.

Understanding the Basics: Blots, Hits, and Safety

A blot is a single checker on a point, and it's vulnerable to being hit. Every move you make involves a choice about where to place (or avoid placing) blots.

Think of playing style as a dial, not a switch. On one end, loose play means leaving blots in order to build structure, gain tempo, or reach key points. On the other, tight play means avoiding blots at almost any cost, prioritising immediate safety. Neither extreme is correct all the time. The right setting depends entirely on the position.

→ For why making points is worth the risk, see Making Points.

The Golden Rule: The Pip Count (The Race)

The pip count is the first thing to check before making the hitting decision:

If you're ahead in the race: lean toward safety. Break contact, consolidate your checkers, and head home. Getting hit when you're winning the race gives your opponent a free chance to catch up.

If you're behind in the race: lean toward aggression. Playing safe when you're losing the race is a strategy for losing slowly. You need to hit something to change the dynamic of the game.

Start here every time. Board structure and the specific game plan can override this, but the pip count is always your first check.

→ For how to calculate and track your pip count, see Pip Counting.

When to Be Aggressive: The Art of Hitting

The Tempo Hit

A tempo hit sends an opponent's checker to the bar, forcing them to spend their next turn re-entering instead of building their position. Even if the hit doesn't gain you a lasting material advantage, it buys you time. Picture this: your opponent is one roll away from making their 5-point. A well-timed hit makes them deal with the bar instead. That's a tempo hit doing its job.

Slotting and Building

Slotting means leaving a blot on a point you want to make, betting that you can cover it next turn. Slot when the target point is valuable enough to justify the risk. Avoid slotting when the opponent has a strong home board, because getting hit against a board with four or five made points is devastating.

Note the difference between slotting and splitting. Slotting places a blot on a point you want to make (usually in your own home board or outer board). Splitting moves one of your back checkers to fight for an anchor in the opponent's board. Both leave blots, but they serve different purposes.

The Blitz

When the opponent has checkers exposed in your home board, hitting them and closing points creates a blitz. The goal is to keep them on the bar while you shut the door. A successful blitz wins gammons. A failed one leaves you with scattered checkers, so recognising when to switch from attacking to consolidating is the key.

→ For the five major game plans (including the blitz), see 5 Core Strategies.

When to Play Safe: Defensive Fundamentals

The Return Shot Danger

Before hitting, look at the opponent's home board. If they have four or five points made, getting hit in return is catastrophic: you re-enter with limited options and the opponent has the structure to trap you. Against a strong opponent board, play safe unless the payoff for hitting is enormous.

Clearing Points Safely

When you're ahead in the race and bearing your checkers in toward home, clear your outer board points from back to front. Avoid leaving a blot that gives the opponent a shot to hit you back into the game.

→ For safe bearing off technique, see Bearing Off.

The Stacking Trap

It's really common to avoid blots by stacking extra checkers on points you already own. It feels safe in the moment, but it's actually a trap. Stacking creates tall, inflexible columns (sometimes called candlesticks) that waste checkers. Five checkers on the 6-point gives you one safe point and four checkers doing nothing. Spreading those checkers out to make new points is stronger, even if it means leaving temporary blots.

→ For how to position builders effectively, see Making Points.

Evaluating Risk: Math and Board Vision

Direct Shots vs. Indirect Shots

The distance between your blot and the nearest opponent checker determines how likely you are to get hit:

Direct shot (1 to 6 points away): the opponent can hit you with a single die. The probability ranges from roughly 30% to 50% depending on the exact distance and any blocking points in between.

Indirect shot (7 or more points away): the opponent needs the combination of both dice to reach you. The probability is significantly lower.

One extra point of distance makes a meaningful difference. A blot sitting 7 points away is substantially safer than one sitting 6 points away.

Duplication

Duplication means forcing the opponent to need the same die number for two different good moves. If hitting your blot requires a 4 and making their key point also requires a 4, they can't do both. Their good numbers overlap, and their effective options shrink. When you have a choice of where to leave a blot, pick the spot that duplicates the opponent's best numbers.

🖼️ **DIAGRAM**
Caption: *Direct vs. indirect shot ranges and hit probability.*
Designer note: Board position showing a single blot with concentric zones radiating from it. Zone 1-6 is coloured as 'direct shot range' (warmer/danger colour) with approximate hit probabilities for each distance. Zone 7-12 is coloured as 'indirect shot range' (cooler/safer colour). Make the drop-off in probability visually clear.

FAQ

Why does the computer suggest hitting when it looks loose?
Because the bots calculate the full picture: the probability of getting hit back, the value of the tempo gained, and the positional advantage of sending the opponent to the bar. A hit that looks risky often gains more than the safe alternative, especially when you're behind in the race or when the opponent's home board is weak.

Is it better to run or hit in the opening?
It depends on the roll and the position. In general, hitting gains tempo and disrupts the opponent's development. Running escapes a checker from danger. The bots tend to favour hitting when the opponent's home board is open (early in the game, it usually is). As the game develops and boards get stronger, the balance shifts.

Is it worth hitting if it leaves a direct shot?
Often, yes. A direct return shot has roughly a 30-50% chance of hitting you back, which means 50-70% of the time you get away with it. If the hit gains you a significant positional advantage (sending a key checker to the bar, buying a tempo, breaking an anchor), the reward outweighs the risk in many positions.

What is the difference between slotting and splitting?
Slotting places a blot on a point you want to make, typically in your own home board or outer board. The goal is to cover it next turn and secure the point. Splitting moves one of your back checkers forward to fight for an anchor in the opponent's board. Both leave blots, but slotting builds your offense while splitting improves your defense.

When to prioritize safety over building structure?

When you're ahead in the race and the opponent is looking for a shot to get back into the game. In that situation, every blot you leave is a free opportunity for them. Consolidate, bear in cleanly, and let your pip count advantage do the work.

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. When you are behind in the pip count, you generally:
○ Play safe and protect your checkers
◉ Play aggressively and look for hitting opportunities ← Correct
○ Focus on bearing off as quickly as possible

2. A direct shot means a blot within how many points of an opponent checker?
○ 4 points
◉ 6 points ← Correct
○ 8 points

3. What is duplication?
○ Having two checkers on the same point
◉ Forcing the opponent to need the same die number for two different good moves ← Correct
○ Rolling the same number on both dice

BEGINNER · 5 min read

Backgammon: Bearing Off

The rules for removing checkers from the board, the mistakes that cost games, and how to finish without giving one back.

Bearing off is how you actually win a game of backgammon. Once all 15 of your checkers are in your home board, you start removing them from the board entirely. First player to clear all 15 wins. The rules are straightforward, but this is the phase where sloppy play gives back games that were already won. The good news: a little care goes a long way here.

→ For every term in this article defined in one place, see Backgammon Glossary.

What is Bearing Off in Backgammon?

Bearing off is the final phase of the game. You can only begin once all 15 of your checkers are on points 1 through 6 (your home board). Not 14. All 15. If you have even a single checker anywhere else on the board, including on the bar, it has to get back to your home board before you can bear anything off.

Getting to this stage first is a big advantage, but mistakes here -- leaving a blot, wasting pips, misjudging the opponent's threats -- can hand that advantage right back.

→ For the full rules of backgammon from the start, see How to Play Backgammon.

How to Bear Off: Rules and Mechanics

On each turn, you use your dice rolls to remove checkers from the board:

Exact match: roll a 4, and you can bear off a checker from the 4-point.

Roll higher than your highest occupied point: if you roll a 6 but your highest checker is on the 4-point, you bear off from the 4-point. The extra pips are not wasted here -- you just take the highest checker off.

No checker on the rolled point but higher points still occupied: you have to move a checker forward within the home board instead. You can't bear off from a lower point when higher ones still have checkers on them.

Doubles give you four moves as usual. Roll double 5s and you can remove up to four checkers from the 5-point (or make four legal moves within the home board).

One rule that catches people off guard: you're not required to bear off if you have a legal move within the home board instead. Sometimes moving a checker forward is the safer play, especially when bearing off would leave a blot exposed.

🕹️ **INTERACTIVE**
Caption: *Bear off a checker: use the dice roll to remove a checker from your home board.*
Designer note: Home board with checkers spread across points 1-6. Display a dice roll (e.g., a 5 and a 3). The user drags a checker from the 5-point off the board, then moves or bears off using the 3. On success, show a brief explanation of the bearing off rule applied. Include a second scenario where the user rolls higher than the highest occupied point to demonstrate the overshoot rule.

Basic Bearing Off Strategy

Efficiency

Every pip that doesn't remove a checker is a wasted pip. Picture this: you roll a 6 but your highest checker is on the 2-point. You take it off, but 4 pips just vanished for nothing. Spreading your checkers across your home board before bearing off begins reduces this waste and helps you clear the board faster.

The ideal setup has checkers spread evenly across all six points. Heavy stacks on one or two points lead to big rolls being partially wasted.

Avoiding Blots and Hits

If your opponent still has checkers nearby -- in your home board, on the bar, or holding an anchor -- leaving a blot during bearing off is dangerous. A hit sends your checker all the way back to the bar, and it has to travel the entire board to get home before you can resume bearing off. That can easily cost you the game.

When the opponent has contact:

Bear off from the highest occupied points first to clear them.

Avoid leaving gaps between your remaining checkers that would expose a blot.

If you have to choose between bearing off a checker and moving one to safety, safety often wins.

The doubling cube adds pressure during bearing off. If you're bearing off smoothly with no contact, you're in a strong position to double (or redouble). If the opponent holds an anchor in your home board, they have cube leverage because a single hit can reverse the game.

→ For when to hit vs. play safe in close-contact bearing off, see Hitting vs Playing Safe.

Winning a Gammon or Backgammon

If you bear off all 15 checkers and your opponent hasn't removed any, that's a gammon (worth 2x the stake). If they also have a checker stuck in your home board or on the bar, it's a backgammon (worth 3x the stake).

A player who is in danger of being gammoned will fight hard to bear off at least one checker, because the difference between a single loss and a gammon loss is huge. In match play, this distinction can decide the entire match.

→ For how gammons and backgammons affect scoring in match and money play, see How Scoring Works.

FAQ

Can I bear off if my opponent has a checker in my home board?
Yes. The only requirement for bearing off is that all 15 of your own checkers are in your home board. Your opponent's checkers don't affect your ability to start bearing off. However, if the opponent has a checker in your home board or nearby, you need to be careful about leaving blots, because a hit will send your checker to the bar and delay your bearing off.

Do I have to bear off if I can make a legal move inside the home board?
No. If you have a legal move within the home board, you can choose to play it instead of bearing off. This is sometimes the correct play: moving a checker forward to avoid leaving a blot is often safer than bearing off and exposing a gap.

Can I bear off from the 4-point if I roll a 6?
Only if there are no checkers on the 5-point or 6-point. When you roll a number higher than your highest occupied point, you bear off from the highest point. But if any checker sits on a point higher than the 4-point, you must move it forward first (you can't skip over it to bear off from a lower point).

What happens to the doubling cube during bearing off?
The doubling cube remains active throughout bearing off. If you have a strong bearing off position (ahead in the race, no contact), you can double to increase the stakes. If your opponent

is bearing off with contact and gets a hit, they can use the cube too. Cube decisions in bearing off positions are often the most consequential in the game.

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. When can you start bearing off?
○ After hitting at least one opponent checker
◉ Once all 15 of your checkers are in your home board ← Correct
○ After the doubling cube has been turned

2. You roll a 5 but have no checker on the 5-point. You have checkers on the 6-point and the 3-point. What do you do?
○ Bear off from the 3-point
◉ Move a checker from the 6-point to the 1-point ← Correct
○ Forfeit that die

3. Why is leaving a blot during bearing off risky when the opponent has contact?
○ It gives the opponent an extra turn
◉ A hit sends your checker to the bar, and it must travel the full board to return ← Correct
○ Blots during bearing off count as double points for the opponent

INTERMEDIATE · 7 min read

Backgammon: When to Double

Moving beyond gut feeling to a framework for doubling decisions.

The → The Doubling Cube article covers what the doubling cube is and how it works: the mechanics, the rules, the flow of ownership. This article is about the next step: knowing when to turn the cube. A well-timed double is worth more than any individual checker play, because the cube is where the biggest swings in points happen. And the good news is that a few clear guidelines will take you a long way.

The Golden Rule: Woolsey's Law

Here's the most useful guideline you'll learn for cube decisions. It comes from Kit Woolsey: "If you are not sure whether your opponent has a take or a drop, double."

Think of it as a superpower. In practice, every position falls into one of three categories:

Clear take: your opponent is happy to accept. Don't double yet: you'd just be handing them the cube without enough pressure.

Clear drop: your opponent loses by accepting. Double, and they will drop (or they'll make a mistake by taking).

Unsure: this is where Woolsey's Law shines. If it's a close decision, double. Close decisions are where your opponent is most likely to make an error. This single rule will improve your cube handling more than any other guideline in the game. Try it for a few sessions and you'll feel the difference.

The Core Concept: Market Losers and Volatility

Let's break this down one piece at a time.

A market loser is a roll that improves your position so dramatically that your opponent would refuse a double on the following turn. If you have several market losers among your 36 possible dice outcomes, that's a signal to double now, while they still have a reason to accept.

Here's a good habit to build: before a cube decision, take a quick look at how many of your rolls are market losers. If more than a third of your rolls would flip the position from "they should

take" to "they should drop," the double is almost certainly right. If only a handful are, you can afford to wait.

Volatility is a related idea: it just means how much a position can change in a single roll. Picture this: your opponent is on the bar and you've made four points in your home board. One roll could close the board completely, or they could roll the exact number they need to come in and hit you back. That's a high-volatility position. In volatile positions, double early. Quieter positions (like a long, grinding race) give you more room to wait.

Basic Doubling Math

Don't worry, the math here is simpler than it looks.

The 25% Rule

On the receiving side: if your chance of winning is above 25%, accepting a double is better than dropping over the long run. You're risking 1 point to win 3, and at 25% those numbers balance. Just ask yourself, "Can I win about one time in four from here?" If yes, take.

Take Points and Cash Points

The take point is the minimum win probability where accepting a double breaks even. In money play, that's 25%.

The cash point is where your opponent should always refuse a double, because accepting loses value in the long run.

Between these two values is the doubling window: that's the sweet spot where you want to offer the cube. If your opponent's winning chances fall inside this window, it's time to double.

In match play, take points shift based on the score. A player who's trailing badly has a lower effective take point because the extra points from a win are worth more to them. Always glance at the match score before making a cube decision, because it changes the picture.

→ For a full breakdown of racing math and pip count technique, see Pip Counting.

Positional Doubling Guides

When to Double in a Race

In a pure race (no contact, both sides bearing in), the pip count drives the decision. A handy guideline is the 8-9-12 rule:

8% pip count lead: you're approaching the doubling window. Start thinking about it.

9% lead: a correct double in most race positions.

12% lead: your opponent is right on the edge of a take. Beyond this, they drop.

The percentages refer to your lead as a proportion of the total race length.

🖼️ **DIAGRAM**
Caption: *The doubling window in a race.*
Designer note: A horizontal bar or number line showing pip count percentage lead from 0% to 15%. Mark three zones: 'No double' (0-7%), 'Doubling window' (8-12%), and 'Opponent drops' (12%+). Keep it clean and simple.

When to Double in Contact Positions

The Blitz

When your opponent is on the bar and your home board is closing, the position is highly volatile. One roll can close the board completely or let the opponent back in. Go ahead and double early in blitz positions, because you want to charge for your advantage before the dice change the picture.

The Prime

When you have opponent checkers trapped behind a wall, the decision depends on whether you want the gammon. If your prime is strong and the opponent's position is collapsing, you might be "too good to double": the expected value of playing for a gammon is higher than the guaranteed 1 point from a drop.

→ For more on building and maintaining a prime, see Building a Prime.

Holding Games

When the opponent is holding an advanced anchor (such as your 5-point), the cube decision takes a bit more thought. The game can turn on a single shot. Double when the race favours you and the opponent faces awkward moves that force them to break their anchor.

Money Play vs. Match Play

Money Play

The Jacoby Rule encourages early doubling in money games because gammons don't count at the base 1-point stake. If you want gammons to matter, you need to turn the cube first.

Watch out for beavers: if your double is too aggressive, your opponent can take and immediately redouble, keeping the cube. This is a money play convention that keeps overly loose doubling in check.

Match Play

The match score changes everything. A player trailing 1 to 6 in a match to 7 doubles on the first roll of every game, because losing 1 more point barely hurts compared to the upside of playing for 2.

The Crawford Rule removes the cube for one game when a player is 1 point from winning. After the Crawford game, the trailing player doubles immediately every game (they have nothing to lose).

At certain scores, the leader can take "free drops": declining a double with minimal cost to their match chances. Recognizing when free drops are available is a skill that pays off quickly in tournament play, and it's easier to spot than you might think.

→ For the five game plans that inform every cube decision, see 5 Core Strategies.

Common Cube Errors

Doubling too late: waiting until you're nearly certain means the opponent drops every time. You collect 1 point instead of playing for 2. The best doubles are the difficult ones. Get comfortable with that feeling.

Fear of doubling: passive cube play lets opponents steal games. If the position calls for a double, trust your read and act on it. Leaving the cube in the centre when you have an edge is one of the most common ways to leave points on the table over time.

Steam doubling: we've all been there. You lose a heartbreaker and immediately double out of frustration in the next game. Try to catch yourself. Every cube decision stands on its own merits,

regardless of what happened in the previous game. Take a breath, look at the board, and decide fresh.

→ For how positional reading feeds into cube decisions, see Reading the Position.

FAQ

When is the right time to double in backgammon?
The right time is when your opponent faces a genuinely difficult decision between taking and dropping. Woolsey's Law captures this: if you're unsure whether they have a take, double. Waiting for certainty costs you equity because the opponent will simply drop every time.

What is the Crawford Rule?
The Crawford Rule states that when one player reaches one point away from winning the match, the doubling cube isn't available for the next game. After that single Crawford game, the cube returns to play. The trailing player then doubles on the first roll of every subsequent game.

What is the difference between a beaver and a redouble?
A redouble is a normal cube turn: the player who owns the cube turns it to the next level. A beaver (used in money play only) is an immediate redouble by the player who was just doubled, and the beaver keeps the cube on their side. It punishes premature or reckless doubles.

How do you calculate the take point in a match?
Use match equity tables. Find the equity at the current score if you drop, and the equity if you take and win versus take and lose. The take point is the win probability where taking and dropping produce the same match equity. At most scores, the take point differs from the 25% money-play baseline.

Why do professional players double so early?
They understand that the cube gains value from uncertainty. The more volatile and contested the position, the more pressure the cube applies. Doubling early forces the opponent into a difficult decision while maximizing the number of market losers. Waiting removes that pressure.

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. Woolsey's Law says that when you are unsure, you:
○ Wait for more information
◉ Double ← Correct
○ Always take

2. In the 8-9-12 rule, a 12% pip count lead means:
○ Clear double, opponent happily takes
◉ Opponent has a borderline take ← Correct
○ Too early to double

3. Why double early in a blitz?
○ Because the race is always in your favour
◉ Because high volatility means one roll can swing everything ← Correct
○ Because the opponent cannot beaver in a blitz

INTERMEDIATE · 6 min read

Backgammon Pip Counting

What the pip count is, why it drives your biggest decisions, and how to calculate it at the table.

A note on online play: if you play on backgammon.com, the pip count is displayed automatically on screen. You don't need to calculate it manually during online games. This article is essential for live tournament play and for understanding why the pip count matters in every game, online or over the board.

The pip count is the single most important number in backgammon. It tells you who is winning the race, it drives your doubling decisions, and it tells you whether your strategy should be running for home or staying back to fight. This is the one skill that will make the biggest difference in your game. And it's easier to pick up than you might think.

→ For how the pip count fits into a full positional read, see How to Play Backgammon.

What is Backgammon Pip Counting?

Your pip count is the total distance (measured in points) that all of your checkers must travel to bear off. Each checker's contribution is equal to the point number it sits on. Three checkers on the 6-point contribute 18 pips. Two on the 4-point contribute 8. Add up all 15 checkers and you have your total pip count.

The player with the lower count is ahead in the race. The player with the higher count is behind. Once you know these numbers, you stop guessing and start making decisions based on real information.

Why the Pip Count Matters in Strategy

The pip count is relevant in three main ways:

Racing decisions: once contact between the two sides is broken, the player with the lower pip count leads the race. The size of the lead determines whether to double. Pip count and doubling cube decisions are directly linked: you can't make a correct cube action in a race without knowing the count.

Cube decisions: a pip count lead of 8 to 12% of the total race is the standard window for offering a double in a pure race. This is where the numbers meet the real-world pressure of the cube.

→ For the full doubling framework, see When to Double.

Strategic direction: if you're far behind in the pip count, running home is a losing strategy. Instead, hold an anchor, look for hitting chances, and try to change the game. If you're well ahead, break contact and race. Just knowing who is ahead gives you a clear direction.

→ For how to choose between running and fighting, see 5 Core Strategies.

How to Count Pips: Popular Techniques

Direct Counting

The straightforward approach: add up every checker one by one. It's slow, but it's accurate, and it's how everyone starts. Don't worry if it feels clunky at first -- that's completely normal. A useful shortcut is to memorize the starting pip count (167 for each player at the beginning of every game) and then track changes as moves happen rather than recounting from scratch. This tracking method gets faster with practice and is the foundation for all the other techniques.

Cluster Counting Backgammon

Group checkers visually rather than counting them individually. Five checkers on the 6-point is 30 pips. Two on the 13-point is 26. Adding clusters is faster than adding individual checkers, and most players find this method strikes the best balance between speed and accuracy.

The key to cluster counting: mentally shift checkers to nearby reference points you can multiply quickly. Move two checkers from the 13-point to the 14-point and one from the 15-point to the 14-point, and you have three checkers on the 14-point (42 pips) instead of adding 13 + 13 + 15 separately. The total is the same, but the arithmetic is simpler.

This is widely considered the fastest backgammon pip counting method for over-the-board play.

Relative Counting

Instead of counting both sides separately, count only the difference. Cancel out matching checkers and count what remains. This is efficient when you just need to know who is ahead and

by how much, without needing the exact totals. Relative counting works best when the positions are similar and you want a quick read on the race margin.

🕹️ **INTERACTIVE**
Caption: *Pip counting trainer.*
Designer note: Show a random mid-game board position. The user counts the pip total for one side and submits their answer. Show the correct count with a breakdown of how cluster counting would approach it. Include a timer (optional). Start with simple positions (few checkers) and progress to full-board positions.

Using the Pip Count: Basic Formulas

The 8-9-12 Rule

For pure race positions: an 8% lead in pip count means you're approaching doubling range. A 9% lead is a correct double. A 12% lead puts the opponent at a borderline take. These percentages refer to your lead as a fraction of the total race length (both counts combined).

Example: if the total combined pip count is 160 and you lead by 15 pips, your lead is about 9.4%. That puts you squarely in doubling territory.

The Rule of 62

Here's a handy shortcut: in a medium-length race, if your pip count is 62% or less of the combined total, you have a healthy lead. It's a rough check, not a precise tool. But it's quick to work out at the table and useful for confirming your read before making a cube decision. Think of it as a gut-check formula.

Beyond the Raw Number: Effective Pip Count (EPC)

The raw pip count can be a bit misleading. The effective pip count adjusts for wastage -- pips that get thrown away during bearing off because you roll higher numbers than you need.

Here's an example to make it concrete. Five checkers stacked on the 6-point have a raw count of 30 pips, but they waste a lot during bearing off because high rolls overshoot repeatedly. Five checkers spread across points 1 through 5 have a raw count of only 15 pips, and they waste much less. The stacked position has a higher effective pip count. Good checker distribution means lower wastage and a truer pip count.

This gap between raw count and effective count is biggest when checkers are bunched on high points or when very few checkers remain. In close races, getting this right is the difference between a correct double and a blunder.

→ For more on how distribution affects the endgame, see Bearing Off.

Tools and Practice Drills

On backgammon.com, the pip count is displayed automatically during games, which is helpful for study and for verifying your mental count. In live play and tournaments, you count manually. Speed comes with practice.

Start by verifying the 167 starting count at the beginning of each game. This gives you a reliable anchor point.

Track changes as moves happen rather than recounting the entire board. Each die you play moves a checker that many pips forward. Keep a running total.

Try counting random positions for 30 seconds each until it becomes second nature. Set up positions on backgammon.com and see if you can get the count before looking at the displayed number.

Compare raw count to effective count in bearing-off positions to train your feel for wastage.

→ For how the pip count informs your approach to hitting decisions, see Hitting vs Playing Safe.

FAQ

What is a safe pip lead to double?
In a pure race, a 9% lead relative to the total combined pip count is a correct double in most positions. A 12% lead puts the opponent at a borderline take. These numbers shift in match play based on the score.

What is the fastest way to count pips?
Cluster counting is the fastest practical method for most players. Group checkers onto reference points you can multiply quickly, then add the clusters. With practice, you can count a full board in under 10 seconds.

Does pip count matter if you are not racing?

Yes. Even in contact positions, the pip count tells you whether your strategy is to run or to stay and fight. A large pip deficit means you need to hit and contain, not disengage. The pip count drives your game plan selection.

What is the difference between raw count and effective count?
Raw count is the simple total of point values for all checkers. Effective count adds an adjustment for wastage: pips lost during bearing off from rolls that overshoot. Stacked or poorly distributed checkers have a higher effective count than their raw number suggests.

Can I use a pip counting app during a live tournament?
No. Tournament rules prohibit electronic assistance of any kind during play. You must count manually. Online platforms like backgammon.com display the count automatically, but over-the-board play requires the skill in your head.

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. What is the starting pip count for each player?
○ 147
◉ 167 ← Correct
○ 187

2. Why is cluster counting faster than direct counting?
○ It skips checkers on the bar
◉ You group checkers onto reference points you can multiply quickly, then add the clusters ← Correct
○ It only counts checkers in the home board

3. In the 8-9-12 rule, a 9% pip count lead means:
○ Too early to double
◉ A correct double in most race positions ← Correct
○ The opponent should always drop

INTERMEDIATE · 6 min read

Backgammon: Building a Prime

How to construct, extend, and advance a wall of consecutive points that traps your opponent.

A prime is a series of consecutive made points, and it's one of the most powerful structures in backgammon. Nothing passes through a six-point prime -- not a single roll in the game can jump it. Once you get the hang of building one, it's incredibly satisfying. The priming game is about containment: trap your opponent's checkers behind the wall and squeeze their options until the game is yours.

→ For how priming fits into the five main game plans, see 5 Core Strategies.

What Is a Prime?

A prime is two or more consecutive made points that block the opponent's checkers from moving past. The larger the prime, the harder it is to escape:

4-prime: restricts movement significantly. The opponent needs a specific combination to leap over it.

5-prime: a serious barrier. Escape requires rolling one of very few combinations.

6-prime (full prime): the maximum. No single roll can jump six consecutive points. The opponent is trapped until you break it.

A prime built inside your home board creates a closed board (also called a shutout). A prime in your outer board blocks the opponent's escape routes. Both are powerful.

🖼️ **STATIC IMAGE**
Caption: *A six-point prime trapping an opponent checker.*
Designer note: A single board position showing a complete 6-prime (six consecutive made points) with one opponent checker trapped behind it. Label the six consecutive points clearly. Include a "no escape" indicator showing that no single dice roll can clear six points. Clean and focused on one prime type.

Core Principles of the Blockade Strategy

Picture this: your opponent has two checkers stuck behind a five-point wall. Those checkers can't contribute to the race, can't make points in their own board, and can't threaten you. The longer they stay trapped, the more your advantage grows.

Trapping checkers also increases your chances of winning a gammon, because the opponent can't bear off checkers that are stuck on the wrong side of a six-point wall.

→ For more on making individual points, see Making Points.

How to Build a Prime

Key Points to Secure

Start with the 5-point and the bar point (7-point). These two anchor any prime between your home board and outer board, and they're the most valuable individual points on the board for building a wall.

Using Builders

Bring builders down from the midpoint and the 8-point. Spread them across your outer board so that as many dice combinations as possible let you make a new point on the next roll. Try not to stack extra checkers on points you already own -- those extras aren't helping you extend the wall.

Slotting for the Prime

Slotting (placing a blot on a key point in hopes of covering it next turn) is more justified in a priming game than in other situations. The reward of extending the prime by one point is often worth the risk of losing a checker.

→ For when to slot versus when to play safe, see Hitting vs Playing Safe.

🕹️ **INTERACTIVE**
Caption: *Click to extend the prime by one point.*
Designer note: Board with a 4-prime already in place and builders in the outer board. Highlight the two points that would extend the prime (one on each end). User clicks one point to place a checker there, then the prime extends to a 5-prime. Single click interaction. Show a brief note on which builder position made the extension possible.

Walking the Prime (The Advance)

Walking a prime means advancing the entire wall toward your home board. The technique: break the back point of the prime and use those checkers to make a new point at the front. The wall shifts forward one point at a time, maintaining its structure while moving closer to home.

Keeping the wall intact is critical. Even a one-point gap gives the opponent a chance to escape. The catch is that walking requires spare moves. If you run out of useful things to do and start crunching (breaking your own points because you have nothing else to play), the prime falls apart.

This is where timing comes in. The best priming positions have extra checkers (spares) that absorb awkward rolls without forcing you to break the wall. Having enough of those spare moves is what separates a winning prime from a crumbling one.

Priming vs. Blitzing

The blitz and the prime are backgammon's two attacking strategies, and they work differently:

Blitz: hitting and closing. Aggressive, high variance. You're trying to shut the opponent out completely.

Prime: blocking and trapping. Positional, controlled. You're containing the opponent and grinding them down.

In practice, a blitz that stalls often transitions into a priming game. The opponent manages to anchor, but their checkers are still trapped behind the points you made during the attack. The checkers you used to blitz become the wall that traps.

→ For how the cube changes when you have a prime, see When to Double.

Counter-Strategies: Facing a Prime

When you're the one trapped behind a prime, your options are limited -- but it's not hopeless. You need to maintain your own board while waiting for the opponent to roll awkwardly and leave a gap. If the opponent is forced to crunch their position, that creates your escape opportunity. Patience is your best friend here.

Hold your own points as long as possible. Every roll that forces you to break your board weakens your position further if you do escape. The goal is to keep your home board intact so that if the prime breaks, you still have a fighting chance.

→ For backgammon terminology like "crunching" and "timing," see Glossary.

FAQ

What is the best way to make a 6-point prime?
Start by securing the 5-point and bar point, then fill in the gaps. Spread builders across your outer board so that the maximum number of dice combinations extend the wall. Build from the middle outward rather than from one end.

How do you walk a prime without breaking it?
Break the back point of the prime and use those checkers to make a new point at the front. You need spare checkers to absorb awkward rolls that would otherwise force you to break a point in the middle of the wall. Timing (having enough useful non-prime moves) is the key.

Is a 6-point prime invincible?
No single roll can escape it, but it's not permanent. The player holding the prime eventually runs out of timing and must start breaking points. When the wall cracks, the trapped checker gets a chance to escape. A prime wins by converting the trapping advantage before timing runs out.

What is the difference between a blitz and a prime?
A blitz attacks by hitting and closing your home board, trying to shut the opponent out entirely. A prime attacks by building consecutive points that trap opponent checkers. Blitzes are fast and volatile. Primes are slow and controlled. A stalled blitz often becomes a priming game.

When is it right to slot to make a point?
Slot when the reward of completing the prime outweighs the risk of being hit. In a priming game, extending the wall by one point is a large gain. If your opponent's home board is weak (meaning a hit costs you little), slotting is correct more often than in other game types.

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. How many consecutive points does a full prime have?
○ 4
◉ 6 ← Correct
○ 8

2. Which two points are most important to secure first when building a prime?
○ The 1-point and the 2-point
◉ The 5-point and the bar point (7-point) ← Correct
○ The 3-point and the 4-point

3. What causes a prime to collapse?
○ The opponent rolling doubles
◉ Running out of timing and being forced to break your own points ← Correct
○ The opponent offering a double

BEGINNER → INTERMEDIATE · 7 min read

10 Common Backgammon Mistakes

The specific errors that hold players back, and what to do instead.

In backgammon, a "blunder" is a move that costs you real winning chances. Every player makes them -- yes, even the strong ones. The difference between a beginner and an intermediate is simply how many of these they have cleaned up. Here are the ten most common errors, starting with the ones that cost the most. Chances are you'll recognise a few of your own habits in here, and that's a good thing. Spotting the pattern is the first step to fixing it.

Strategic Opening and Structural Errors

1. Ignoring the 5-Point

The 5-point (also called the golden point) is the most valuable point on the board. It anchors your home board, starts a prime, and blocks the opponent's escape route all at once. Players who use early rolls to make less important points while the 5-point is available are giving up their biggest asset. If you have a choice between making the 5-point and making any other point, make the 5-point.

→ For which opening rolls make the 5-point, see Best Opening Moves.

2. Stacking Checkers (Candlesticks)

Piling five or more checkers on a single point feels safe, but those extras are just sitting there doing nothing. They're not making other points, not serving as builders, and not contributing to a prime. Getting checkers off those heavy piles (especially the 6-point) is an early priority in every game. The 6-point stack at the start of the game is one of the first things to sort out with your opening moves.

→ For how to put those checkers to work, see Making Points.

3. Making Deep Points Too Early

Making the 1-point or 2-point in the first few rolls removes checkers from active play. Those points become useful later in the game (during a blitz, for example), but early on, you need your

checkers connected and flexible. Keep them active in the outer board and the top of the home board.

Checker Play and Movement Mistakes

4. Playing Too Safely

Avoiding blots at all costs leads to stagnation. Calculated risks -- slotting a key point, splitting your back checkers -- build the structure you need to win. Playing tight while your opponent develops freely is a strategy for losing slowly. The bots all agree: most newer players play too safely, not too aggressively. The correct play is often the one that looks a bit risky at first glance.

→ For how to evaluate risk versus reward on each move, see Hitting vs Playing Safe.

5. Hitting Without Thinking (Revenge Hitting)

Hitting just because you can is a tempting habit. Before every hit, ask yourself: does this improve my position, or does it break my own structure? If your home board is weak (so the opponent re-enters easily) or you're already winning the race (so you don't need the contact), letting the blot go is often the smarter play.

6. Ignoring the Pip Count

Not knowing the pip count means not knowing whether to run or stay. If you're ahead in pips, break contact and race home. If you're behind, hold an anchor and look for a hit. The pip count drives this decision, and playing without it is guessing.

→ For counting methods and formulas, see Pip Counting.

Cube Handling and Endgame Missteps

7. Doubling Too Late

Waiting until you're "sure" you're going to win means the opponent drops every time. You collect 1 point instead of playing for 2. The best doubles are the ones where the opponent has a genuinely difficult decision. If they always drop your doubles, you're doubling too late. This one

adds up quietly -- over dozens of games in a session, all those missed points make a real difference.

→ For doubling frameworks and Woolsey's Law, see When to Double.

8. Taking Bad Doubles

If your win probability is below 25% in money play, dropping is the better long-term play. We've all taken a double we should have dropped -- nobody likes conceding. But those pride takes cost real points over time. Knowing when to drop is just as important as knowing when to double.

9. Bearing Off Unsafely Against an Anchor

When the opponent still holds a point in your home board, bearing off carelessly leaves blots. A hit during the bearing off phase sends your checker all the way back to the bar, and you can't bear off again until it returns. Smooth your distribution before bearing off, and avoid leaving gaps on the 5 or 6-points.

→ For safe bearing off technique, see Bearing Off.

Mental Game

10. Playing on Autopilot

Moving instantly without scanning for alternatives is one of the most expensive habits in the game. The obvious move is often correct, but the positions where it isn't are exactly where the biggest gains happen. Give yourself a moment on cube decisions. Pause when the position looks unusual. That extra five seconds of thought can be worth several points over a session.

Try building the habit of checking for one alternative play before committing. On backgammon.com, there's no clock pressure in most game modes. Take advantage of that.

FAQ

What is the biggest mistake beginners make in backgammon?

Playing too safely. Newer players avoid leaving blots at all costs, which prevents them from making key points and building structure. The bots all agree: overly cautious play costs more than any other single error pattern.

When is it a mistake to hit?
When your home board is weak and the opponent will re-enter easily, or when you're already ahead in the race and the hit creates unnecessary contact. Hitting is a tool with a purpose (sending back, gaining tempo), not an automatic reflex.

How do I know if I am doubling too late?
If your opponents drop almost every double you offer, you're doubling too late. The best doubles produce a close decision for the opponent. Track how often your doubles are taken versus dropped over a session.

Why is the 5-point called the Golden Point?
Because it's the single most valuable point on the board. It blocks the opponent's escape from your home board, anchors a prime, and strengthens your inner board for blitzing. Making the 5-point early changes the character of the entire game in your favour.

Is it always right to take a checker off if I can?
No. When the opponent holds an anchor in your home board, bearing off from the high points can leave blots that get hit. Sometimes it's better to move checkers to safer points first, especially on the 5 and 6-points where gaps create problems.

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. Stacking is a mistake because:
○ It is against the rules to have more than 5 checkers on a point
◉ Those extra checkers are not making other points or building a prime ← Correct
○ The opponent can hit stacked checkers

2. Why is making the 1-point or 2-point too early a mistake?
○ Those points are illegal to make before the midgame
◉ It removes checkers from active play when you need them connected and flexible ← Correct
○ The opponent can jump over low points

3. What is the danger of playing on autopilot?
○ You will always leave blots
◉ You miss the non-obvious positions where the biggest gains happen ← Correct
○ The doubling cube resets to 1

INTERMEDIATE · 7 min read

Reading the Backgammon Position

A thinking framework for evaluating any board position.

Here's the thing about reading a backgammon position: you don't need to figure it out from scratch every time. There's a simple framework that weighs four factors, points you toward the right game plan, and helps you make a decision. Once you get used to it, every board position becomes a question you know how to approach, even if you're not sure of the answer yet.

Four Things to Check

Every backgammon position comes down to four things. The weight you give each one depends on what's happening in the game, but all four are always worth a look.

The Race: Pip Counting and Visual Estimation

Who is closer to bearing off? The pip count answers this directly. A significant lead means you're winning if the game becomes a pure race. A deficit means you need contact (hits, anchors, primes) to stay alive.

Beyond the raw count, effective pip count (EPC) adjusts for how your checkers are arranged. Checkers stacked on high points waste pips during bearing off. Spread checkers are more efficient. Two players with the same raw count can have very different actual racing chances.

→ For counting methods and the 8-9-12 rule, see Pip Counting.

Structure: Primes, Anchors, and Board Strength

What do you own on the board? The key assets are:

A prime traps opponent checkers and restricts their movement.

A strong home board (four or five points made) punishes any hit you land.

An anchor in the opponent's board provides safety and a base for a holding game.

The 5-point is the most valuable single asset on either side of the board. Holding it (yours or theirs) changes the character of the position.

→ For how to build and walk a prime, see Building a Prime.

Flexibility: Connectivity and Builder Placement

Can you improve your position on the next roll? This factor is about future potential.

Builders (spare checkers in range of key points) mean more useful rolls on the next turn.

Stripped points (exactly two checkers with no spares) are fragile. One move and the point breaks, leaving a blot.

Connected checkers (no large gaps between groups) allow smoother movement. Disconnected groups create problems.

Safety: Blots and Volatility

How exposed are you right now?

Blots near opponent checkers are in immediate danger.

Volatility (how much the position can swing on a single roll) determines urgency. High volatility means the position won't stay this way for long. Act now.

🖼️ **DIAGRAM**
Caption: *The four factors annotated on a single position.*
Designer note: One mid-game board position with four annotation zones. (1) Race: pip counts displayed for both sides with the leader indicated. (2) Structure: prime highlighted, anchor circled. (3) Flexibility: builders marked with arrows showing what they can reach, stripped points flagged. (4) Safety: blots flagged with danger indicators showing direct/indirect shot exposure. Clean layout with a legend.

Classifying the Game Plan

Reading the position is only useful if it leads to a decision about what you're trying to do. Here's how to use the four factors to classify the position:

Racing and Holding

Ahead in pips with minimal contact? Race. Behind in pips but you've got an anchor? Hold and wait for a shot. The race factor and structure factor together tell you whether you're in a racing game or a holding game.

Priming vs. Blitzing

Opponent checkers trapped behind your consecutive points? That's a prime. Opponent checkers exposed in your home board? That's a blitz. A prime looks like neat rows of made points. A blitz looks like scattered checkers and active combat. In practice, a stalled blitz often transitions into a prime.

→ For a full breakdown of the five game plans, see 5 Core Strategies.

The Backgame

You hold multiple deep anchors, you're way behind in the pip count, and your only path is to hit a late shot. This is a timing game: the safety and flexibility factors tell you whether your board can survive long enough for the shot to appear.

→ For how individual points form these structures, see Making Points.

From Analysis to Action: The Doubling Cube

A good positional read leads directly to cube action. Here's how the four factors connect:

Position clearly in your favour across most factors? Check for market losers and consider doubling.

Close decision? Apply Woolsey's Law: if unsure, double.

Receiving a double? Think about your 25% threshold across all four factors, not just the race.

This four-factor check is what separates a thoughtful cube decision from a guess. Each factor contributes to your overall chances, and the cube decision flows from that total picture.

→ For the full doubling framework, see When to Double.

Tools for Improving Your Read

Picture this: you just finished a game and you're wondering, "Should I have doubled on that turn? Was my read right?" On backgammon.com, you can review your completed games and compare your decisions against the analysis engine. The platform gives every position a score: basically a number that represents how well you're doing from that spot. Reviewing your games against these scores shows exactly where your reads went wrong and which of the four factors you're misjudging.

Your performance rating (PR) tracks how close your decisions are to the best possible play. Think of it like a golf score, where lower is better. Tracking your PR over time on backgammon.com is the clearest measure of improvement. Try to review at least one game per session, focusing on the positions where your move and the engine's move differed. This is where the learning really happens.

FAQ

How do you calculate win probability in backgammon?
Win probability comes from evaluating all four factors (race, structure, flexibility, safety) and estimating how often each side wins from the current position. In practice, analysis engines on backgammon.com calculate this by simulating thousands of possible continuations. Over the board, experienced players estimate it from pattern recognition.

What is the fastest way to count pips?
Cluster counting. Group checkers onto nearby reference points you can multiply quickly, then add the clusters. Most players can count a full board in under 10 seconds with practice.

What does equity mean in backgammon?
Equity is a way of measuring how good your position is, expressed as a number. Think of it like a score for the current board: a positive number means you're ahead, a negative number means you're behind. An equity of +0.5 means you expect to gain about half a point on average from this position. Every move and every cube decision changes your equity, and the goal is to pick the option that gives you the best number.

How do you know if you have a take or a drop?
Look at your winning chances across all four factors. In money play, if your total winning probability is above 25%, take. In match play, the threshold varies based on the score. Use the four-factor check to estimate whether your combination of racing chances, structural strengths, flexibility, and safety adds up to enough winning potential.

When is the right time to break your prime?

Break your prime when you have no other productive moves (you're crunching) or when you've already converted the prime's advantage into a winning race. If the opponent's checkers are still trapped and you have timing, keep the prime intact. If you're running out of spare moves, start walking the prime toward home before it collapses on its own.

TEST YOUR KNOWLEDGE

1. The four factors for reading a position are:
○ Offence, defence, speed, and luck
◉ Race, structure, flexibility, and safety ← Correct
○ Pip count, prime, anchor, and blitz

2. Stripped points are a concern because:
○ They have too many checkers to be useful
◉ One move breaks them and leaves a blot ← Correct
○ The opponent can jump over them

3. High volatility in a position means:
○ The position is stable and unlikely to change
◉ The position can swing dramatically on a single roll ← Correct
○ Both players have established primes